From Rivermind to Care Homes

Settler Dreams and Britain's Care Crisis

The cannibalistic business model depicted in *Common People* holds up a mirror to Britain's predatory social-care infrastructure.

NEEREJ DEV

In *Black Mirror's* season-seven opener, *Common People*, a slick sales rep promises salvation through Rivermind—an always-on, cloud-hosted brain patch that is "free" only until the monthly fees metastasise. What looks like speculative fiction is, in truth, also a veiled x-ray of Britain's social-care economy, which has become an ouroboros, sustained by consuming the workers it purports to sustain.

Nancy Fraser calls such dynamics "cannibal capitalism"—a societal order that piles up monetised value for investors, "while devouring the non-economised wealth of everyone else." Director Ally Pankiw translates Fraser's thesis to the screen. "Our pricing is really reasonable," Tracee Ellis Ross's ever-smiling Gaynor remarks during her first sales pitch, "And then for the streaming, we run a subscription model." The trap is sprung in that single euphemism. Rivermind's free brain surgery is tethered to a £300-a-month subscription whose ever-steeper tiers eventually swallow both love and solvency.

Capitalism cannibalises care, democracy, and nature alike; *Common People* shows how easily it cannibalises personhood

Migrants recognise that script. First, you bankroll an international-student degree with a high-interest education loan or family-borrowed cash that will shadow you for a decade, and discover you're capped at 20 hours' work a week, so you pray for the Christmas break, when the Home Office briefly lets you hustle full-time. Next, you pay for a post-study work visa, only to find that most graduate jobs quietly require applicants who already hold indefinite leave to remain. Shut out of the "real jobs" club, you pivot to the lone sector still dangling sponsorship: social care. There, a Health and Care Worker visa beckons—just wire a four-figure agency fee, swallow the £1,000-plus annual "thank-you-for-your-service" health surcharge, renew a visa that costs more than a car and lodge a five-week rent deposit for a bedsit with a 1984 boiler. The pay? Low enough that you consider a second job, until you learn your visa locks you inside one occupation code. Freedom of work turns out to be the brochure's biggest fiction; the British dream is really an endlessly upgrading subscription plan, and the final tier comes with debt you'll be wiping down for years.

The so-called "settler dream" referenced here differs from the broader migrant aspiration. It signals a particular fantasy of arrival, rooted in Britain's colonial hangover. One that has made you believe in the transition from periphery to metropole, not only to work but to belong. Academics like Nandita Sharma and Aihwa Ong have shown how this fantasy is shaped by post-colonial hierarchies and stratified citizenships, in which legal belonging is contingent, conditional, and constantly repriced. Unlike traditional settler colonialism, where land and status are extracted from others, here it is the migrant's own future—labour, savings, even love that is steadily devoured.

Rivermind's stealth "feature upgrade" has a precise analogue in Britain's real-time repricing of settlement. Yesterday's £60 monthly energy direct-debit is today's £95 "standing-charge adjustment," National Health Service (NHS) dental appointments remain a mythical reward for the truly patient migrant, and one Home Office circular can raise the immigration health surcharge, visa fee or salary threshold. Only once you're locked in do you learn how elastic the price of simply staying alive can be.

In this landscape, survival isn't intuitive; it must be learned, often in real time. Influencers on TikTok, Instagram and YouTube serve as para-bureaucrats, translating each policy tweak into do-it-yourself tutorials. But in doing so, they also normalise extreme downward mobility as a necessary immigrant bargain. Maria Cecilia Hwang classifies these creators as "digital migration intermediaries" whose lifestyle reels blur personal testimony with soft-sell marketing. These platforms reproduce structural asymmetries: glossy success stories travel friction-free, whereas accounts of debt, depression and deskilling "stick" only in marginal online spaces, effectively disappearing from the algorithmic mainstream.

When Rivermind's demands outpace their earnings, Mike (Christopher O'Dowd) sells self-harm on Dum Dummies. His final "speciality stream" is almost certainly suicide for a private buyer. Britain's social-care sector stages the same spectacle off-screen. Private agencies charge migrants up to £15,000 for jobs with tied visas and harsh rotas. My own fieldwork at a faded seaside town in Essex found careers with postgraduate degrees from universities in the United Kingdom (UK) in chemistry and electrical engineering, and medical degrees from India, among others, repaying £13,000 "sponsorship packages." Others had come directly to the UK on Health and Care Worker visas, lured by promises of stable work and residence—naturally, for an exuberant agency fee. As on Dum Dummies, suffering itself becomes revenue; private middlemen skim the proceeds.

As of April 2025, the UK government's national living wage, the legal minimum for those aged 21 and over, stands at £12.21 per hour, while the real living wage, calculated by the Living Wage Foundation based on the actual cost of living, is £12.60 across

the UK and £13.85 in London. The gap between legal sufficiency and survival is where capitalism thrives. As Fraser warns, capitalism cannibalises care, democracy, and nature alike; *Common People* shows how easily it cannibalises personhood.

"Lovin' You" by Minnie Riperton plays at the hotel. The lyric, "Everything that I do is out of loving you," becomes a cruel refrain, capturing the essence of what unfolds: from the opening scene, where Amanda's and Mike's bare feet tangle lazily beneath a sunlit duvet, to the moment when Mike lowers a pillow over her face. In that final scene, Amanda (Rashida Leah Jones) whispers, "Do it when I'm not here," just as her consciousness is hijacked by Rivermind's ad-roll. *Common People* feel intimate because its horrors unfold not in dystopian megacities but in the marital bedroom, the staff lounge: the very spaces where exploitation is negotiated daily.

This issue transcends technology and economics into gendered labour and institutional complicity. According to Skills for Care's 2023/24 report, women constitute approximately 79% of the adult social care workforce in England. During the same period, 1,05,000 international recruits joined the care sector, with nearly 29% of them male. This is almost double the proportion of UK-born staff and marks a demographic shift in a historically feminised workforce. These migrants enter a care infrastructure that is structurally dependent on their presence, yet systematically underpays, undervalues, and confines them within low-mobility visa regimes. These workers fill jobs where the time-intensive nature of care makes productivity gains nearly impossible, thus keeping wages low and attrition high. Marketisation only deepens this dependence, with profit-driven care homes cutting costs while workers absorb the debt, dislocation, and emotional toll.

Common People ends in silence but leaves us with a question worthy of Fraser's closing plea to "lay the cannibal to rest": How long before love, labour and even legal presence are pay-per-view subscriptions?

Until then, Britain's migrant care economy will continue to refresh its browser, buffering through the slow death of its own humanity.

Neerej Dev (neerejdev@gmail.com) is a doctoral researcher at the University of Wolverhampton, United Kingdom.